

KEY TOPIC 3: ATTEMPTS AT A SOLUTION, 1974–95

Paper 2: Conflict in the Middle East, 1945–1995



COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: Why has peace proved so elusive in the Middle East?

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L1: KT 3.1: Diplomatic Negotiations: From Shuttle Diplomacy to Camp David, 1974–1979

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the significance of the oil crisis and the involvement of the USA and the USSR.
- ☐ Analyze Kissinger, 'shuttle diplomacy' and the reopening of the Suez Canal.
- ☐ Evaluate Sadat's visit to Israel (1977), Begin's visit to Egypt (1977), US President Carter and Camp David (1978) and the Treaty of Washington (1979).

In an unprecedented move that stunned the world, Egyptian President Anwar Sadat traveled to Jerusalem in 1977, offering peace. This bold step shattered the Arab taboo of refusing to talk to Israel and paved the way for the historic Camp David Accords, fundamentally altering the Middle East peace process.

Did you know?

- **Camp David Accords (1978):** Brokered by US President Jimmy Carter, leading to the first peace treaty between Israel and an Arab nation.
- **Sinai Return:** Israel agreed to return the entire Sinai Peninsula to Egypt in exchange for full diplomatic recognition.
- **Assassination:** Sadat was viewed as a traitor by many Arabs and was assassinated by Islamic extremists in 1981.

Do Now Activity

On what Jewish holy day did Egypt and Syria launch their surprise attack in October 1973?

What weapon technology did Egyptian forces use to breach the sand ramparts of the Bar-Lev Line in 1973?

What action taken by Arab oil-producing states (OPEC) during the 1973 war caused a global economic crisis?

Who was the US Secretary of State who pioneered "shuttle diplomacy" between Middle Eastern capitals in 1974–75?

In what year was the Suez Canal finally cleared and reopened to international commercial shipping?

Who was the Egyptian President who stunned the world by flying to Jerusalem to address the Knesset in November 1977?

Who was the right-wing Likud Prime Minister of Israel who negotiated with Sadat?

What presidential retreat in Maryland hosted 13 days of intense secret negotiations brokered by US President Jimmy Carter in 1978?

What was the formal peace treaty signed on the White House lawn in March 1979 called?

What territory did Israel agree to return entirely to Egyptian sovereignty under the 1979 treaty?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

OPEC | Shuttle Diplomacy | Likud | Camp David Accords | Treaty of Washington

In the years following the Yom Kippur War, Henry Kissinger utilized exhaustive _____ to mediate initial disengagements like the _____ between Israel and its neighbors. A major political shift occurred in Israel with the election of the right-wing _____ party, led by Menachem Begin. Despite Begin's hardline stance, intense negotiations with Egypt led to the historic _____ in 1978. This framework ultimately resulted in the 1979 _____, marking the first formal peace treaty between Israel and an Arab nation amidst an era of global economic _____ influenced by _____.

Source S1 : Sadat visits Jerusalem



Egyptian President Anwar Sadat, who made a historic and unprecedented visit to Israel in 1977 to pursue peace.

Operation Peace for Galilee (June 1982): Ariel Sharon's Invasion: The Yom Kippur War of October 1973 was a military conflict that triggered a global economic and geopolitical revolution. Alarmed by the massive US arms airlift to Israel (Operation Nickel Grass), the Arab members of OPEC (Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries) enacted the "Oil Weapon." They placed a total oil embargo on the United States, Denmark, and the Netherlands, while cutting production for other Western nations by 25%. This move had a devastating, cascading impact on the global economy. The price of crude oil quadrupled in a matter of months, skyrocketing from \$3 to \$12 a barrel. Western industrial nations, highly dependent on cheap oil, plunged into a deep economic crisis characterized by soaring inflation (rising prices) and high unemployment. As oil prices rose, production costs increased, making goods more expensive; consequently, consumers bought fewer items, leading to factory bankruptcies and mass layoffs.

The Siege of Beirut & The Expulsion of the PLO to Tunisia:

cognitive_impact

The Sabra and Shatila Massacre (September 1982): For the superpowers, the crisis changed the calculation of Middle Eastern diplomacy. The Yom Kippur War had brought the United States and the Soviet Union to the brink of a nuclear confrontation. The United States, badly hit by the embargo, now had a powerful financial incentive to broker a lasting peace between Israel and its Arab neighbors to ensure the stable flow of Middle Eastern oil. Furthermore, US policymakers wanted to use diplomatic negotiations to pull Egypt out of the Soviet sphere of influence. Because Egypt and Syria refused to meet face-to-face with Israeli officials, US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger stepped in as a mediator.

Kissinger pioneered a form of negotiation known as "shuttle diplomacy," flying back and forth between Cairo, Damascus, and Tel Aviv for two months to relay messages, draft proposals, and bridge the deep psychological divide between the hostile states.

Q1. How did the 1973 Yom Kippur War change the diplomatic calculations of the United States?

The Kahan Commission: Domestic Israeli Backlash & Sharon's Resignation:

 shuttle_diplomacy

The Rise of Hezbollah: Shia Resistance in Southern Lebanon: Kissinger's efforts produced three highly important interim agreements. The Sinai I Agreement (January 1974) saw Israeli forces pull back from the west bank of the Suez Canal, creating a UN-patrolled buffer zone. The Golan Accord (May 1974) brokered a cease-fire line on the Golan Heights, with Israel withdrawing from Quneitra. The Sinai II Agreement (September 1975) saw Israel surrender the strategic Gidi and Mitla passes and the vital Abu Rudeis oil fields to Egypt. Crucially, the US established manned early-warning electronic monitoring stations in Sinai to guarantee compliance. A direct consequence of Kissinger's Sinai I agreement was the clearing of the Suez Canal. The canal had been blocked since the 1967 Six Day War by sunken ships and landmines. On 5 June 1975—exactly eight years to the day after its closure—President Anwar Sadat officially reopened the Suez Canal to international trade, providing a major boost to the Egyptian economy.

Q2. What was the result of Henry Kissinger's Sinai II Agreement (September 1975)?

Source S2 : The Camp David Accords (1978)



Begin, Carter, and Sadat shaking hands after successfully negotiating the Camp David Accords.

The Roots of Domestic Palestinian Frustration in Gaza and the West Bank: By 1977, the momentum of Kissinger's shuttle diplomacy had stalled. In May 1977, the right-wing Likud bloc came to power in Israel, with Menachem Begin installed as Prime Minister. Begin firmly believed in Israel's biblical claim to the entire Land of Israel, including the West Bank. Most observers assumed Begin's election would end all hopes of peace.

 sadat_faces

However, Anwar Sadat was facing severe internal pressures, a failing economy, and food riots in Cairo. Sadat realized only a dramatic, direct gesture could break the diplomatic deadlock. On 19 November 1977, Sadat's presidential plane landed at Ben Gurion Airport in Israel. The following day, he addressed the Israeli Knesset, offering Israel complete recognition and permanent peace in exchange for complete Israeli withdrawal from all occupied Arab lands. On 25 December 1977, Menachem Begin made a reciprocal visit to Ismailia, Egypt, for a summit with Sadat. However, this historic meeting failed to produce a breakthrough, and by mid-1978, direct talks between Egypt and Israel had once again broken down over Begin's refusal to dismantle Jewish settlements in the Sinai. To rescue the process, US President Jimmy Carter took a massive political risk, inviting both Sadat and Begin to the presidential retreat at Camp David, Maryland, for face-to-face negotiations.

Q3. What dramatic gesture did Anwar Sadat make on 19 November 1977 to break the diplomatic deadlock?

 camp_david

For 13 days, Carter acted as a tireless mediator. The grueling summit resulted in the signing of the Camp David Accords on 17 September 1978. Framework 1 addressed the wider Palestinian issue, agreeing to a five-year transitional period of autonomy for the West Bank and Gaza Strip. Framework 2 outlined a bilateral peace treaty: Israel agreed to a phased, complete withdrawal from the Sinai Peninsula, and Egypt agreed to normalise relations. On 26 March 1979, Begin, Sadat, and Carter signed the formal Treaty of Peace between Egypt and Israel (the Treaty of Washington). Israel returned the entire Sinai Peninsula to Egypt, which became demilitarised. In return, Egypt officially recognized Israel's right to exist, becoming the first Arab nation to do so. The Suez Canal and the Straits of Tiran were permanently open to Israeli maritime shipping.

Q4. Outline the key terms of Framework 2 of the 1978 Camp David Accords.

Source S3 : The Egypt-Israel Peace Treaty (1979)



Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin, who signed the historic Egypt-Israel Peace Treaty in 1979.

 sinai_returned

While celebrated in the West, the peace treaty triggered a massive geopolitical backlash in the Middle East. The Arab League expelled Egypt for abandoning the Palestinian cause. Tragically, on 6 October 1981, Anwar Sadat was assassinated by radical Islamic militants within the Egyptian army who opposed

his peace with Israel. Begin also faced furious opposition from hardline settlers, but the Knesset approved the treaty with a massive majority of 84 votes to 19.

Q5. What was the tragic personal consequence for Anwar Sadat following the signing of the peace treaty?

Q6. Explain one consequence of the 1973 Oil Crisis for diplomatic negotiations in the Middle East. (4 marks)

Pair & Share Activity

Q7. Was Anwar Sadat a courageous visionary or a traitor to the Arab cause? Justify your view.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q8. Explain one consequence of the Camp David Accords (1978). (4 marks)

L2: KT 3.2: The Palestinian Issue: Lebanon, Sabra & Shatila, and the First Intifada, 1974–1993

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand Arafat's speech to the UN (1974) and the significance of PLO activities in Lebanon.
- ☐ Analyze Israeli reprisals, the invasion of Lebanon (1982) and the results.
- ☐ Evaluate the situation in the Israeli occupied territories and the First Palestinian Intifada (1987–93).

While Egypt and Israel made peace, the Palestinians felt abandoned. Operating out of Lebanon, the PLO launched relentless attacks against Israel, leading to the devastating 1982 Israeli invasion of Lebanon. By 1987, Palestinian frustration inside the occupied territories exploded into a spontaneous, grassroots uprising known as the First Intifada.

Did you know?

- Lebanon War (1982): Israel invaded Lebanon to destroy the PLO, resulting in thousands of civilian casualties.
- Intifada (1987): Meaning 'shaking off', this was a massive Palestinian uprising in the West Bank and Gaza involving strikes and stone-throwing.
- Hamas: Formed during the Intifada, this militant Islamic group emerged as a rival to the secular PLO.

Do Now Activity

What famous speech did Yasser Arafat deliver to the UN General Assembly in 1974 holding an olive branch and a freedom fighter's gun?

What was the name of the 1978 agreements negotiated by Carter, Sadat, and Begin in Maryland?

What was the formal peace treaty signed between Egypt and Israel in March 1979?

What territory did Israel return to Egypt in exchange for peace and demilitarisation?

How did the Arab League punish Egypt for signing a separate peace treaty with Israel in 1979?

What happened to Egyptian President Anwar Sadat in October 1981?

Which Israeli Defense Minister orchestrated the June 1982 invasion of Lebanon?

What was the official codename for the 1982 Israeli invasion of Lebanon?

What notorious massacre of Palestinian refugees took place in Beirut in September 1982 by Christian Phalangist militiamen?

To which North African capital was Yasser Arafat and the PLO leadership evacuated in August 1982?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

UN Resolution 3236 | Fatahland | Operation Peace for Galilee | Sabra and Shatila | First Intifada | Hezbollah

Your Sentence:

Source S1 : The First Intifada (1987)



Palestinian youth confronting Israeli troops during the First Intifada, a spontaneous grassroots uprising.

The Spark in Jabalya (8 December 1987): The Uprising Erupts: Following the 1973 Yom Kippur War, the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) sought to capitalize on the shifting geopolitical landscape to advance its diplomatic standing. On 13 November 1974, PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat made a historic address to the United Nations General Assembly in New York. This invitation was highly significant, representing the first time a representative of a non-state national movement was permitted to address the UN General Assembly plenary. Arafat, who delivered his speech wearing his signature checkered keffiyeh and olive-green uniform, famously concluded his remarks with a powerful metaphorical warning: "I have come bearing an olive branch and a freedom fighter's gun. Do not let the olive branch fall from my hand."

The Dynamics of the Intifada: Stones Against Tanks:



The UNLU (Unified National Leadership of the Uprising): Grassroots Power: This dual-track message signaled that while the PLO was prepared to engage in international diplomacy to secure a sovereign Palestinian state, it would not abandon its armed struggle if diplomatic avenues were blocked. The diplomatic offensive yielded immediate results at the UN. Resolution 3236 formally recognized the inalienable rights of the Palestinian people to self-determination, and granted the PLO permanent Observer Status. At the Arab League Summit in Algiers, the PLO was officially recognized as the "sole legitimate representative of the Palestinian nation." Following its bloody expulsion from Jordan during the "Black September" civil war of 1970, the PLO relocated its central leadership, military apparatus, and thousands of fighters to Lebanon. Lebanon was an ideal haven: its central government in Beirut was weak, and the country already hosted over 400,000 Palestinian refugees living in camps.

Q1. What was the significance of UN Resolution 3236 (November 1974) for the PLO?

The Rise of Hamas (1987): Islamic Resistance Challenges the Secular PLO:



Yitzhak Rabin's "Iron Fist" & The Global Media War: By the mid-1970s, the PLO had established a powerful "state-within-a-state" in southern Lebanon, widely known as "Fatahland". The PLO operated its own checkpoints, collected taxes, ran hospitals, and established military training camps. From these bases, PLO guerrilla fighters launched cross-border raids and fired Katyusha rocket barrages into northern Israel, terrorizing the civilian settlements of the Galilee region. On 11 March 1978, a Fatah commando unit launched the Coastal Road Massacre, hijacking a civilian bus and engaging in a gun battle that resulted in the deaths of 37 Israeli civilians. In direct retaliation, Prime Minister Menachem Begin ordered the IDF to launch Operation Litani on 15 March 1978.

Q2. What was 'Fatahland' and how did it threaten Israeli security?

Arafat's Diplomatic Shift: Geneva (1988) & Recognition of Israel:



The Gulf War (1991): Arafat Backs Saddam Hussein & Loses Arab Aid: Over 26,000 IDF troops invaded southern Lebanon, occupying a 10-kilometer-wide security strip. The UN established the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL) to confirm the Israeli withdrawal. Israel withdrew but left control of the buffer zone to a friendly, pro-Israeli Christian militia known as the South Lebanon Army (SLA). The UNIFIL buffer failed to stop the conflict. The final trigger for full-scale war occurred on 3 June 1982, when the Abu Nidal Organization shot and critically wounded Shlomo Argov, Israel's ambassador to Great Britain. Although British intelligence confirmed the PLO was not responsible, Israeli Defense Minister Ariel Sharon used the assassination attempt as the necessary pretext to launch a long-planned, total invasion of Lebanon: Operation Peace for Galilee.

Q3. What pretext did Israeli Defense Minister Ariel Sharon use to launch Operation Peace for Galilee in June 1982?

Source S2 : Israeli Response to the Intifada



Israeli Prime Minister , who implemented a harsh 'Iron Fist' policy in response to the Intifada.

The Madrid Conference (1991): Setting the Stage for Direct Talks:



On 6 June 1982, Israeli forces launched a massive armored invasion. Ariel Sharon secretly harbored much larger geopolitical ambitions: to completely destroy the PLO in Lebanon, defeat Syrian forces, and install a pro-Israeli Christian government in Beirut led by Maronite leader Bashir Gemayel. By mid-June, Israeli forces surrounded Lebanon's capital, trapping Yasser Arafat and 15,000 PLO fighters in West Beirut. For over two months, Israel subjected the city to relentless bombardments. To prevent total destruction, a multinational peacekeeping force supervised the evacuation of Yasser Arafat and over 14,000 fighters by ship to Tunis, Tunisia.

Q4. What were Ariel Sharon's larger geopolitical ambitions behind the 1982 invasion of Lebanon?

Having successfully expelled the PLO, Israel's close Maronite ally, Bashir Gemayel, was elected President of Lebanon. However, on 14 September 1982, Gemayel was assassinated in a massive bomb blast by Syrian agents.



In response to the assassination, the IDF occupied West Beirut. On 16 September 1982, Israeli forces surrounded the Palestinian refugee camps of Sabra and Shatila. Claiming PLO terrorists remained inside, Ariel Sharon authorized the Lebanese Christian Phalangist militias to enter the camps to clear them. Fueled by anger over the death of Gemayel, the Phalangists systematically slaughtered unarmed civilians. While the IDF held the perimeter and illuminated the night skies with flares, the militias murdered between 800 and 3,500 people. The revelation of the atrocities triggered immediate, furious international condemnation. The extraparliamentary peace movement "Peace Now" organized a protest of 400,000 Israelis in Tel Aviv. The Kahan Commission concluded that Defense Minister Ariel Sharon bore "personal, indirect responsibility" for the tragedy. He was forced to resign.

Q5. Describe the events and consequences of the Sabra and Shatila massacre in September 1982.



While the PLO leadership remained isolated in Tunis, the core of the Palestinian struggle shifted back to the occupied territories. On 8 December 1987, an Israeli military truck collided with a civilian car, killing four Palestinians. The local population erupted in massive demonstrations that swept across Gaza and the West Bank, marking the start of the First Palestinian Intifada ("The Shaking Off").

Q6. What event marked the start of the First Palestinian Intifada in December 1987?

Source S3 : PLO Exile in Lebanon



Source

Yasser Arafat, leader of the PLO, whose organization was forced into exile in Tunisia following the 1982 Lebanon War.



Unlike the PLO operations, the First Intifada was a grassroots, popular civilian uprising utilizing non-violent civil disobedience (strikes, boycotts) alongside low-level street violence. The iconic visual of the Intifada consisted of Palestinian youth throwing stones at heavily armored Israeli tanks. Israeli Defense Minister Yitzhak Rabin responded with a severe "Iron Fist" policy, ordering the IDF to "break the bones" of demonstrators. However, television cameras broadcasted graphic footage of heavily armed soldiers beating stone-throwing children across the globe. For the first time, global public sympathy shifted decisively toward the Palestinian cause, severely damaging Israel's international moral standing.

Q7. How did the First Intifada shift global public sympathy toward the Palestinian cause?

CONSEQUENCES OF THE FIRST INTIFADA

For the PLO	For Israel	The Rise of Hamas
Forced Yasser Arafat to renounce terrorism and officially accept the two-state solution (1988) to retain leadership.	Convinced Yitzhak Rabin and military planners that there was no purely military solution to the Palestinian issue.	Formed in 1987 as a rival to the PLO, Hamas rejected compromises and conducted violent armed attacks against Israelis.

Writing Historically: Level 9 Stylistic Masterclass

GCSE history examiners actively look for clear, sophisticated written expression that demonstrates analytical links between historical causes, events, and consequences.

- **1. Using Relative Clauses to Pack in Evidence (AO1):** Add vital historical information directly to a noun using relative pronouns like 'who', 'which', or 'whose'. For example: *Yasser Arafat, **who addressed the UN General Assembly in 1974 wearing his signature keffiyeh and military uniform, successfully secured international legitimacy...***
- **2. Using Noun Phrases in Apposition (AO1):** Place two noun phrases side-by-side to provide concise historical detail. For example: *Ariel Sharon, **the hardline Israeli Defense Minister**, launched Operation Peace for Galilee in June 1982.*
- **3. Using Present Participles (AO2):** Link cause and effect using verbs ending in '-ing'. For example: *...Palestinian guerrillas launched frequent cross-border attacks, **provoking** disproportionate Israeli military reprisals.*

Q8. Write a narrative account analysing the key developments of the PLO in Lebanon in the years 1970–82. (8 marks)

Pair & Share Activity

Q9. Why was the First Intifada more damaging to Israel's international reputation than their previous wars with Arab armies?

GCSE Exam Practice

Q10. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the First Intifada (1987–1993). (8 marks)

Planning your narrative account:

Remember to link your paragraphs chronologically. You could use these sentence starters:

- *The first key event was...*
- *This directly led to...*
- *Consequently, this triggered...*
- *This situation culminated in...*

L3: KT 3.3: Attempts at a Solution: From the Oslo Accords to Oslo II, 1988–1995

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the significance of Arafat's renunciation of terrorism in a speech at the UN (1988).
- ☐ Analyze changing superpower policies in the Middle East: US involvement in the Gulf War (1991), and the end of the Cold War.
- ☐ Evaluate Arafat, Rabin and the Oslo Accords (1993); the setting up of the Palestinian National Authority; the Israel-Jordan peace treaty (1994); and Oslo II (1995).

The sheer exhaustion of the Intifada forced both sides to the negotiating table in secret. In 1993, the world watched in awe as PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat and Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin shook hands on the White House lawn, signing the Oslo Accords. It seemed peace was finally possible, but extremists on both sides were determined to destroy it.

Did you know?

- Oslo Accords (1993): Created the Palestinian Authority with limited self-rule in parts of the West Bank and Gaza.
- Mutual Recognition: The PLO finally recognised Israel's right to exist, and Israel recognised the PLO as the representative of the Palestinians.
- Assassination of Rabin (1995): A right-wing Israeli extremist assassinated Yitzhak Rabin, severely derailing the peace process.

Do Now Activity

What Arabic term meaning "shaking off" refers to the grassroots Palestinian uprising that broke out in 1987?

In which dense refugee camp in the Gaza Strip did the First Intifada begin in December 1987?

What primary weapon did Palestinian youths use against Israeli soldiers that captured global media attention?

What significant concession did Yasser Arafat make in an official speech to the UN in Geneva in December 1988?

What major international war in 1991, prompted by Saddam Hussein's invasion of Kuwait, reshaped Middle Eastern diplomacy?

Why did the PLO lose financial and diplomatic backing from wealthy Gulf states like Kuwait and Saudi Arabia during the 1991 Gulf War?

What global historical event in 1991 stripped Syria and the PLO of their primary superpower sponsor and military weapons?

Who was elected Prime Minister of Israel in 1992 on a campaign pledge to pursue peace with the Palestinians?

In which European city did Israeli and Palestinian negotiators conduct secret talks in 1993?

What self-governing administrative body was established under the Oslo Accords to govern parts of the West Bank and Gaza?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **UNLU**

Source S1 : The Oslo Handshake (1993)



Yitzhak Rabin, Yasser Arafat, and Bill Clinton sealing the Oslo I Accord on the White House lawn.

The Secret Negotiations in Norway: Circumventing the Hardliners: By late 1988, PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat realized that the political landscape was shifting beneath his feet. The First Palestinian Intifada had been launched and coordinated by grassroots local committees on the ground, bypassing the traditional PLO leadership isolated in Tunis. Arafat faced a major dilemma: his leadership was being rapidly overshadowed by new, highly popular underground leaders in the Unified National Leadership of the Uprising (UNLU) and radical Islamist groups like Hamas and Islamic Jihad.

Letters of Mutual Recognition: Breaking the Fifty-Year Taboo:



The Declaration of Principles (Oslo I, 1993): The White House Handshake: To regain political control, Arafat enacted a historic shift in PLO strategy. In November 1988, the Palestinian National Council officially accepted the principles of partition and a two-state solution—officially recognizing Israel's right to exist alongside a sovereign, independent Palestinian state in the occupied territories. In December 1988, on the strict insistence of the United States, Arafat delivered a historic speech to a special session of the UN General Assembly in Geneva. In this speech, Arafat explicitly renounced and condemned all forms of terrorism. This met the long-standing US conditions for official diplomatic contact, forcing the Reagan administration to open formal diplomatic talks with the PLO.

Q1. How did Yasser Arafat enact a historic shift in PLO strategy in late 1988?

The Establishment of the Palestinian National Authority (PNA) in Gaza & Jericho: The international geopolitical order was completely transformed between 1989 and 1991. The dissolution of the Soviet Union (USSR) in December 1991 brought an end to the Cold War and fundamentally altered the balance of power in the Middle East.

The 1994 Israel-Jordan Peace Treaty: King Hussein Signs:

Oslo II (1995): Partitioning the West Bank into Areas A, B, and C: The collapse of the USSR was a devastating blow to the PLO, which lost its primary funding and diplomatic backing. Over 200,000 Soviet Jews migrated to Israel, leading to the expansion of Jewish settlements in the West Bank and displacing Palestinian workers. Arafat realized he had to secure a deal immediately. The end of the Cold War also meant the US emerged as the sole global superpower and used its leverage, threatening to withhold a \$10 billion loan guarantee, to force Israel's Prime Minister to negotiate. In August 1990, Iraqi dictator Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait, triggering the 1991 Gulf War. Arafat made the disastrous decision to publicly support Saddam Hussein.

Q2. How did the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 severely damage the PLO's geopolitical position?

Source S2 : Israel-Jordan Peace Treaty (1994)



King Hussein of Jordan, who signed the historic peace treaty with Israel in 1994, normalizing relations between the two countries.

The Fatal Postponement: The Unresolved Final-Status Issues:

The Extremist Backlash: Hamas Suicide Bombings Sabotage the Process: Outraged by Arafat's betrayal, wealthy Gulf Arab states cut off all financial donations. Kuwait expelled over 300,000 Palestinian workers. The PLO was left bankrupt. To stabilize the region, the US and USSR co-sponsored the Madrid Peace Conference in November 1991. While the public talks stalemated, they broke the taboo of direct negotiations. In June 1992, the moderate Labor Party came to power in Israel under Yitzhak Rabin. Rabin authorized secret, back-channel negotiations in Oslo, Norway.

Q3. Why was the PLO left bankrupt and diplomatically isolated following the 1991 Gulf War?

The Assassination of Yitzhak Rabin (4 November 1995): The Death of Peace:

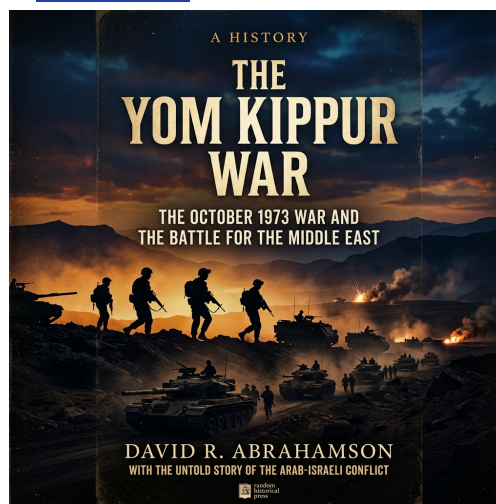
The urgency intensified in April 1993 when Hamas launched its first suicide car bombing. This convinced Rabin that Arafat's PLO was a moderate alternative. The secret negotiations produced the historic Oslo I Accords, signed on the White House lawn on 13 September 1993. Arafat renounced terrorism and recognized Israel, while Rabin recognized the PLO. An interim Palestinian National Authority (PNA) was established to govern Gaza and Jericho. In October 1994, Israel and Jordan signed a formal Treaty of Peace. King Hussein approached Rabin because Jordan was suffering economically after the Gulf War. US President promised to cancel Jordan's massive debts if it normalized relations.

Q4. What convinced Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin to engage in secret negotiations with the PLO in 1993?

israel_jordan

On 28 September 1995, Rabin and Arafat signed the Oslo II Accords, which detailed the expansion of Palestinian self-rule across the West Bank by dividing it into three zones.

Source S3 : Assassination of Yitzhak Rabin



The book cover of 'Yitzhak Rabin: Soldier, Leader, Statesman' depicting Rabin, who was assassinated by an Israeli extremist at a Tel Aviv peace rally.

oslo2

While Oslo II was celebrated, the division triggered a massive political backlash. Palestinians were frustrated that the PNA only controlled a fragmented archipelago (Area A), while Israel still controlled 70% of their land (Area C). Hamas launched suicide bus bombings. Right-wing Israelis were outraged by Rabin's concessions.

Q5. Why did the Oslo II Accords trigger a massive political backlash among Palestinians?

deadlock

On 4 November 1995, Yitzhak Rabin was assassinated at a peace rally in Tel Aviv by Yigal Amir, a radical right-wing Jewish law student. The assassination dealt a fatal blow to the peace process, leaving the "permanent status" issues completely unresolved.

Q6. What event dealt a fatal blow to the peace process on 4 November 1995?

Q7. Write a narrative account analysing the key developments in the peace process between Israel and the Palestinians in the years 1988–95. (8 marks)

The tragic assassination of Rabin highlighted the deep structural flaws of the Oslo Accords. While celebrated internationally as a breakthrough, the agreement was fundamentally ambiguous. It intentionally delayed the most difficult "permanent status" issues—such as the final borders, the status of Jerusalem, the right of return for Palestinian refugees, and the dismantling of Israeli settlements—to a later date. This delay created a dangerous vacuum of uncertainty. Right-wing Israelis viewed any land concessions as a threat to national security and biblical claims, while Palestinian hardliners argued that the PNA had essentially become a subcontractor for Israeli security, failing to deliver true sovereignty or halt settlement expansion. Ultimately, the Accords required a high level of mutual trust that simply did not exist on the ground.

Q8. Explain why the Oslo Accords were considered 'fundamentally ambiguous' and structurally flawed. (12 marks)

Pair & Share Activity

Q9. Looking at the assassination of Rabin, why are peace agreements sometimes more dangerous for leaders than declaring war?

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Q10. Explain the importance of the Oslo I Accord (1993) for the Middle East peace process. (8 marks)